There will be sociopolitical consequences as well, as different nations will adjust their procedures and practices as per a less trusting ethos. From academia to business, from research to travel, the world will see this impact in the coming decade. On top of it all, the political economy and orthodox security will continue to play out.

Who will gain and who will lose when the external environment is less favourable is an interesting proposition. How power differentials assert themselves is no less significant. We have already seen that some players have misread the strategic culture of others, leading to unintended results. A world that is more united in some respects but struggling deeper in others will surely be a novel experience.

The response of states is naturally conditioned by changed circumstances and surroundings. It is, therefore, all the more important that we appreciate the structural changes underway. The reality is that the loosening in the architecture created by the limitations of the US and the rise of China has opened up space for others. We may have two major powers, obviously not quite at the same level. But even this does not translate into traditional bipolarity. There are now many more players whose growth is autonomous and whose weight is increasing. To varying degrees, they will exploit gaps, just as they will take advantage of competition. Some of that will be constrained by their biases, affinities and interests. But as a broad pattern, they will be tempted to make the most of the ambivalence of those more distant. The diversity of alliance interests could be a contributory factor.

We must also appreciate that alliances themselves are a product of a set of circumstances. Copying the broad and durable network created by the US is near impossible. No other power has the capacity to even attempt a serious replication. But changing times produce different models and the unceasing process of establishing a global hierarchy will surely find unique expressions. Economic integration and dependency may now become more determining factors in the emergence of a new order. The possibility of alternatives should not be discounted.

A broader spread of power among nations with less structural rigidity is exactly what defines the arrival of ‘others’ on the world stage. This category may itself be a spectrum, with some having a longer history of power projection and some a more immediate relevance. Again, a few could aspire to be leading powers one day, while some may be simply protecting the